# Road-Trip Day-Of Checks

*A 15-minute walk-around you do the morning you leave — the morning that matters.*

## What this is

Long trips are the one time your car asks to be taken seriously. This is a short, kind checklist for departure morning: car, people, house, and paperwork. Nothing on it needs a mechanic.

## How to use it

1. Print once and keep inside a road-trip folder you reuse.
2. The week before: do page 2 (oil due? tires aging? schedule now).
3. Departure morning: work down page 3 in about 15 minutes.
4. Tape the route + arrival ETAs on page 3 so someone at home always knows where you are.

**Reminder:** for a fully loaded car (roof box, 5 people, luggage), your manual's tire-pressure sticker lists a **higher "full load" PSI**. Use that, not the normal number.

**Printing tips:** print one copy per trip; write the trip name and dates at the top. Tired-brain tip: laminate or sleeve one copy so the same sheet works again and again.

# Road-Trip Prep — The Week Before

Trip name: _____ Dates: _____ Who's going: _____

## Car

- [ ] Book/confirm any due service (check your maintenance schedule printout first)
- [ ] Tires: pressure (set to the sticker number), tread, and a serious look for slow leaks
- [ ] Spare tire: holds air + jack and lug wrench present and you know where they are
- [ ] Oil touching MAX? Coolant between lines? Brake reservoir at MAX?
- [ ] All lights work (walk-around with a helper, 2 minutes)
- [ ] Wipers still clean every pass? Wiper fluid full?
- [ ] Scan for new noises, smells, or warning lights — fix small things now, not on I-80

## House & logistics

- [ ] Hold mail (USPS hold) or arrange pickup
- [ ] Confirm pet/plant arrangements
- [ ] Pay bills that come due while away
- [ ] Download offline maps for the route
- [ ] Confirm hotel + first-night booking
- [ ] Tell one person your route + arrival day

**Verify with your manual:** if you're towing a trailer or small camper, read the manual's towing chapter — weight limits and mirror/brake requirements are model-specific, and they're real limits, not suggestions.

# Departure Morning — 15 Minutes

Do it before the coffee's fully drunk. Two checks need a passenger; the rest take one person.

## Around the car (walk clockwise)

- [ ] Front tires look parked-correct, not saggy (just look — pressure was set this week)
- [ ] Windshield: clean, and you've got working fluid to clear bugs
- [ ] Lights on: headlights, brake lights (helper checks), turn signals, hazards
- [ ] Under the car: no fresh puddles or drips this morning
- [ ] Roof box / bike racks / trailer all strapped + locks engaged
- [ ] Everything loose inside secured — no heavy stuff that can fly in a hard stop (do your manual's load rules: heavy items low and forward)
- [ ] Glovebox stock-up: registration, insurance card, trusty info card

## Inside the car

- [ ] Phone mounts and chargers working
- [ ] Seat + mirrors set for the first driver
- [ ] Snacks + water within arm's reach
- [ ] Kids'/pets' items buckled in
- [ ] Music/podcasts queued (safety first: set before driving)
- [ ] Medications, glasses, contacts packed in cabin (not trunk)

## This-trip card: where are we, and when do we get there

| ROUTE VIA (MAIN TOWNS) | EXPECT ARRIVAL + DATE | HOME CONTACT WHO HAS THIS |
|---|---|---|
| LONGEST STRETCH WITHOUT STOPS (PLAN WATER/REST EVERY ~2 HRS) | | EMERGENCY-IN-TRANSIT PLAN |

- [ ] Fuel/EV charge topped off the night before
- [ ] Seats/suits/last bathroom before the door
- [ ] Trash accounted for (bag + empty bottle plan)
- [ ] One more look: everything's inside that's leaving with you

**Verify with your manual:** fully-loaded road trip = check that full-load tire pressure and any roof-load limits in the manual before you tie anything down.